

**UROMI JUSTICE DEVELOPMENT PEACE AND CARITAS INITIATIVES
(UROMI JDCPI) NEWSLETTER, March, 2022 Edition**

CORPORATE FACT SHEET

Name	Uromi Justice Development Peace & Caritas Initiatives, (Uromi JDCPI).
Owner	Catholic Diocese of Uromi, Nigeria.
Legal Holder	His Lordship, Most Rev. Dr. Donatus A Ogun (OSA)
Authorized Representative & Director	Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Oriabure Arhedo
Corporate Registration No:	CAC/IT/No: 50042 & ED/MWASD/NGOR/200/04
Status	Catholic Non-Governmental, Non-Profit making, Humanitarian and Development Organization.
Motto	Hope for the Oppressed and Empowerment for All
Areas of operation	Integral Development, Human Rights, Democracy, and Good Governance, Alternative Dispute Resolution, Prison Apostolate and Legal Aid services, Peace Building, Micro-Credit and Caritas, TB and HIV/AIDS care and support, HIV Counseling and testing, Livelihood improvement, Anti-Human trafficking and VC programming
Project steered	Conflict Management, Training of Electorate, Election Observation, Budget Monitoring, Community TB Care, HIV/AIDS Awareness Creation & Counseling, Micro-Credit Facilities, Rural Community Development Enlightenment Campaign, Prisoners' Welfare Services, Gender And Child Rights, Widowhood Association, Human Rights, Training Programmes for Police Officers and Youths, Women Development & Promotion through Micro Credit, Emergency Response, Legal Aid, VC Programming, Capacity Strengthening for Good Governance, Campaigns and Sensitizations Against Human Trafficking as well as Creating Alternatives to Human Trafficking through Vocational Skills Acquisition and Empowerment, Human Right Education and Paralegal Scheme, Don't Pay With Your Life, Strengthening Community Participation to Prevent Human Trafficking and Integrated Child Health and Social Service Award
Focus Group	The rural populace, the economically deprived, families, children, students, youths, women and widows living among the poorest of the poor in the society. Inmates in Prison and Ex-inmates, persons stigmatized with deadly diseases.
Physical Address	Inside Uromi Diocesan Chancery at Egbele, Uromi, Edo State, Nigeria.
Postal Address	P.O. Box 7, Uromi, Edo State
E-mail	uromijdcpi@gmail.com

Telephone:	+2348053328588, +2348034930414, +2348150822524
Auditors	1. Grant Thornton chartered Accountants Emgn, Benin Branch 2. Edforte, Fortne, Ehiagwina& Associates 141 Benin-Auchi Road Ekpoma, Edo State
Bankers	• UBA BANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • ECOBANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • FIDELITY BANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • Unity Bank PLC Mission Road Uromi • Union Bank PLC Mission Road Uromi • Zenith PLC Mission Road, Uromi
Staff Strength	21
Number of Community Volunteers	72
Project Executed	18

INTRODUCTION

In furtherance of her mission to alleviate poverty and promote integral development through the motivation and empowerment of the less privileged/oppressed and challenging unjust structures that enhance injustice, hatred and backwardness in Nigeria; Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives otherwise known as Uromi JDPCI executed a number of activities through her various interventions to address issues around human right protection, good governance, human trafficking and Irregular Migration, as well as interventions to promote healthy outcomes amongst children and families infected and affected by HIV/AIDS.

Consequently, Uromi JDPCI under her Human Rights Education and Paralegal Scheme Project whose goal is to contribute towards improving peaceful coexistence of the village communities and promoting social justice and respect for human rights conducted refresher training on Overview of the Nigerian Legal System and Conflict Management for Paralegals and Advocates who constitute membership of the 30 community human right club in Edo Central Senatorial District, executed five community dialogue sessions in five communities across five Local Government Areas (LGA) in Edo Central Senatorial District, oversaw the 4th quarterly meeting of Paralegals and Advocates of the Community Human Right Clubs in the 5 LGAs of the Project SCOPE, conducted the fourth quarterly learning sessions with the school based human right clubs and also convened her 2022 Annual Human Right Conference.

To achieve accountability, transparency and effective service delivery in governance, Uromi JDPCI in partnership with the British Council and the European Union initiated an intervention titled Community Mobilization and Engagement for Transparency, Accountability and Sustainable Governance in Edo Central Senatorial District. Milestones achieved within the period include; Advocacy visits to the 25 project communities and the 5 Head of Local Government Authorities in Edo Central Senatorial District, Project Orientation meeting with the 25 established Civic Groups across the project location and monitoring visits to the Civic groups.

Uromi JDPCI also upheld her efforts in combating the ills of Human Trafficking and Irregular Migration through her multipronged strategies via various Anti-Human trafficking interventions, which includes;

Don't Pay with Your Life (DPWYL) project which saw to the empowerment of 10 caregivers with the sum of ₦50,000 to expand their income generating activities which they were supported to start up in the earlier part of last year 2021, conducted group discussions with project beneficiaries and also monitored the businesses of the supported beneficiaries.

Strengthening Community Participation to Prevent Human Trafficking (SCOPPH-T) project; in which 75 vulnerable students selected through a structured assessment were supported with educational materials and payment of all mandatory school requirements to promote their retention and progression in school. Also, 31 out of the 75 caregivers of the vulnerable adolescents selected from the 26 schools were supported to have Income Generating Activities with the remaining 44 caregivers planned for the next batch. The project also carried out

sensitizations to 11 schools, 9 markets and 3 communities to create awareness of the high risks of trafficking associated with irregular migration, engaged 5 communities in a dialogue so as to ensure that Local authorities, Communities and child protection services have improved understanding of causes and issues associated with human trafficking/irregular migration and are better equipped to contribute to prevention strategies. Other activities conducted were; learning sessions with 10 adolescent school based anti- human trafficking clubs, meetings with support group members across the 5 LGAs and review meeting with volunteers and community watch group representatives.

Under the platform of the SMAT-P (Sustainable Measures Against Trafficking in Persons) project, 32 vulnerable youths were empowered with business start- up kits to build their socio economic capacity and ultimately prevent their susceptibility to human trafficking and irregular migration. This support is a build- on to the empowerment that was done by the Project in the earlier part of year 2021.

Additionally, Uromi JDPCI commemorated the feast of St Josephine Bakhita. The Platform was used to empower 149 persons from the different interventions implemented by Uromi JDPCI.

With the goal to mitigate the impact of HIV/AIDS on orphans and vulnerable children and their caregivers Uromi JDPCI in collaboration with the Association for Reproductive and Family Health is implementing the Integrated Child Health and Social Service Award in 4 Local Government Areas in Edo Central Senatorial District. Key achievements during the period were: Enrollment of 438 Orphans and Vulnerable Children into the program out of which 138 were Children living with HIV, Coordination of Caregivers Forum in Esan South East, Esan West and Esan Central LGAs, the formation of Operation Triple Zero (OTZ) Club for adolescent living with HIV, Financial Literacy training for 85 CLHIV Caregivers, Village Savings and Loan Association(VSLA) Training for Community Case Managers, Support Group meetings with PLHIV in 4 LGAs, and service provision to beneficiaries which includes; 188 birth registrations, assisted referral for HIV Testing and Screening to 497 enrolled beneficiaries with unknown status, Assisted referral for viral load uptake to 56 CLHIV and Early Infant Diagnosis (EID) uptake for 68 HIV exposed infants amongst others

Uromi JDPCI also contributed to the actualization of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 1) in the area of Poverty alleviation, through her long sustained Micro Credit scheme. The Uromi JDPCI Micro Credit Scheme has so far provided soft loan to over 1605 industrious community members in Edo Central Senatorial District in the areas of Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) and Agro allied sectors.

HUMAN RIGHT DESK

HUMAN RIGHT EDUCATION AND PARALEGAL SCHEME IN EDO CENTRAL SENATORIAL DISTRICT

Refresher Training for Community Human Right Members on Overview of the Nigerian Legal System and Conflict Management

Uromi JDPCI in sustaining her commitment to build the capacity of the various Community Human Right Clubs across the 30 project communities on how they can effectively protect and promote the human rights and dignity of members of their communities organized a refresher training on the “Overview of the Nigerian Legal System and Conflict Management” for Paralegals and Advocates who constitute membership of the 30 clubs. The training which was highly interactive took place on the 10th and 11th of February 2022 and was facilitated by Theresa Odion Esq. and Dr. Michael Iyoriobhe respectively.

During the course of the training, participants were exposed to the Administration of the Nigerian Justice System in relation to arrest, search seizure, bail and bail processes amongst others. They were also enlightened on the meaning and types of conflict, its stages, as well the different ways of resolving conflict. Emphasis was laid on litigations and Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) as some of the ways of resolving

conflict. The benefits of employing ADR in resolving conflicts were extensively treated.

Theresa Odion Esq. interactively took participants on Overview of the Nigeria Legal System which bothered on the Nigerian Law, the Nigerian Courts, her personnel as well as the administration of justice system in the country in relation to arrest, search seizure, bail and bail process in order to promote good understanding of the Law.



The Executive Director addressing the participants

Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

Participants who expressed satisfactory knowledge refresher on the topic reacted to one of the bail processes erroneously practiced in the country; which was the Police bail process. They pointed out the fact that although it was a popular slogan that bail was free, experiences had shown otherwise. They



A participant making contributions during the training.

Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

lamented the deplorable state of the situation which seemed to be irredeemable. Responding to the above, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI joined his voice to condemn the exploitative tendencies of some police officers against persons who were deemed innocent before the law until proven guilty by competent Court of Jurisdiction. He expressed hope of a better tomorrow.



Conflict and Conflict Management session with Mr. Michael Iyoriobhe
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

On Conflict and Conflict Management Dr. Michael Iyoriobhe explained that conflict was inevitable to man while stressing how poor or good management of conflict could affect man and the society he lived in. He explained the various types of conflict, its stages, as well as the different ways of resolving conflict. Emphases were laid on litigations and other means of resolving conflicts such as the Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR). He spoke on the benefits of employing ADR in resolving conflicts, while noting that such resolutions were considered for Civil matters alone. It was re-emphasized that rape was criminal and should never be handled as a civil matter.

Notable contributions made by the Participants at the end of the two days training included: The need to manage disagreements which spurs conflict by engaging and promoting peaceful dialogues between the conflicting persons.

Dr. Obasemi Jude, the Executive Director of Escreva Jose Maria Foundation appreciated the efforts of Uromi JDPCI in establishing community structures for the protection of human right. He encouraged participants to cease the opportunity to explore their



Dr. Obasemi Jude exhorting the participants

Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI



Dr. Obasemi Jude exhorting the participants

Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

ground as human right activists, into bringing positive changes in their communities even after the project ends. He recounted how

Uromi JDPCI gave a fertile ground to the good people of Ekpoma Community in ensuring meaningful developments when they established the Civic group under the good governance project which has metamorphosed into a formidable Association known as Concerned Eminent Stakeholders Forum in Ekpoma whose work is to ensure that members of the community have the

dividends of democracy. He appealed to all participants to carry out their good works by getting their facts straight before intervening, so as not to dabble into any indictable matters.

Community Dialogue Held In Five Communities across Edo Central Senatorial District

For the purposes of eliciting and clarifying community viewpoints on the protection of rights of children and widows and to as well dialogue on the need to embrace practices that promotes the human rights and dignity of all in accordance with the provisions of the Nigerian Law and other international legal frameworks that promotes and protect human rights; Uromi JDPCI carried out yet another impactful community dialogue session in five selected communities, namely Amedokian in Esan North East LGA, Ewu in Esan Central LGA, Eguare-Ekpoma in Esan West LGA, Ewossa in Igueben LGA and Ubijaja in Esan South East LGA.



A participant making contributions at Amendiokhian Community

The dialogues which served as an avenue to discuss human right issues peculiar to each of the communities with regards to widowhood practices and Child protection, successfully reached



The Executive Director addressing participants at Amendiokhian Community



A cross section of participants during the dialogue at Ubijaja community

the goal of improving the knowledge and consciousness of human rights among community leaders, thus positioning them to enhance the community justice system and abolish cultural practices that are oppressive and



The Director of Programmes addressing participants in Ewu Community

repugnant to natural justice and the rule of law. A total of 126 (68 Males, 58 Females) were reached at the dialogue

sessions.

4th Quarterly Meeting of the Human Rights Clubs in Edo Central Senatorial District

Uromi JDPCI held her 4th quarterly meeting with Paralegals and Advocates of the 30 community based Human Rights Clubs across the 5 Local Government Areas (LGAs) in Edo Central Senatorial District. The meetings at the various LGAs were held on the 10th, 15th, 16th, 17th and 18th of March 2022 at Esan West, Esan South East, Esan North East, Igueben and Esan Central Local Government Areas, respectively. The meetings provided an avenue to highlight key human rights issues intermediated upon by community Advocates within their communities, the achievements made, challenges encountered and to render durable solutions to the identified challenges.

The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, while appreciating the participants over their tireless efforts in ensuring that the rights of persons were protected in their various communities, admonished them to continually promote justice in their quest for peace amongst the village populace because in the presence of justice, peace was inevitable.



Ubiaja Community Human Right Paralegal giving report

Some of the outstanding achievements by the clubs as highlighted in their reports included; the successful resolution of 5 incidences of domestic violence, the successful reunification of two conflicting families and one separated couple as well as an incidence of spousal abandonment which was resolved with the husband promising to care for his wife and Children, thus leaving the families in peace and harmony. Also, 2 cases of attempted ill-treatment against two Widows on the grounds of widowhood rites were successfully halted and the immediate families as well as members of the communities where the incidents took place were sensitized to shun harmful widowhood practices and the legal implications of subjecting people to such oppressive practices.

Additionally, an incidence of child physical abuse by a guardian as well as emotional and psychological abuses from a mother were mediated upon. Both Caregivers were counseled against such acts while the Children were cautioned to be respectful and obedient to their Parents and currently, there exist a better relationship between the children and their parents.

Also, two incidences of rape that occurred against a minor and an adult respectively were successfully taken to the State CID and referrals made to the Ministry of Social Development and Gender Issues for legal representations.

Unfortunately, a rape incidence which was undergoing intervention by one of the community human right club was truncated by the mother of the victim who disclaimed and lured the victim to



disclaim the incident while in another incidence of attempted rape against a minor, the families of the principle witness and victim refused to allow the case to undergo prosecution.



One of the Human Right Club stopped the community members from implementing an illegal fee which they called

Ebelle Community Human Right Paralegal giving report

Egoro Amede Human Right Paralegal giving report

“Matching fee” against strangers who en-route the community to their various farms by enlightening them on the unjust and illegal acts of freedom of movement infringement on the strangers. Likewise, they educated community members against stopping the educational project of a church establishment as the religious body had the right to establish a school in the community since they followed the due process of the law.

Some of the Advocates also sought to foster unity and better working condition between the custodian of the custom of the people and members of the community by engaging their traditional heads on some practices that seemed to be oppressive to the community members.

Fourth Quarterly Learning Sessions with the School Based Human Right Clubs.

Sequel to the objective to promote knowledge and peer education amongst adolescents on the rights of persons and the subsequent establishments of the school based human right clubs in 25 schools as well as the conductions of trainings and meetings with the school based human right clubs members in the previous quarters, Uromi JDPCI carried out another learning session for all



Obiedu Sec School Human Right Club Members



Ewatto Grammar School Human Right Club Members

the members of the school based human right clubs in the 25 selected schools in Edo Central Senatorial Districts within the month of January to March, 2022. Uromi JDPCI took members of the club on the Protection of the Rights of a Child, Abduction, Guardianship, Adoption and Child Justice Administration.

Emphases were laid on child sexual abuses of minors which was termed rape and the fact that the perpetrators were liable to be imprisoned for life. One shocking realizations portrayed by all the students was the understanding of the fact that there was never a justification to rape, and the gender biases of apportioning female victims to rape was adequately cleared.

At the end of the learning session, the students showed good understanding of the lessons during the interactive questions and answers sessions.



Annunciation Catholic College Human Right Club Members

A report was made by one of the members of the school based human right club concerning a rape victim (child) who was undergoing depression due to the incidence; coupled with the fact that the identity



Ewu Grammar School Human Right Club Members

of her offender was unknown as the act was done in the cover of the night. She asked for advice and possible intervention from Uromi JDPCI who scheduled a meeting with the victim for psychosocial and legal counseling.

The learning sessions have been very impactful especially in debunking misconceptions regarding gender inequalities among the students who saw it as a norm which they must follow.

2022 Uromi JDPCI Annual Human Right Conference Held On the 31st Of March 2022 at the Catholic Chancery Complex, Egbele-Uromi, Edo State

The implementation of the Annual Human Right Conference of Paralegals and Advocates of the Human Right Education and Paralegal Scheme forms Part of the activities of Uromi JDPCI in meeting up with her goal to contribute towards improving peaceful co-existence of the village communities and promoting social justice and respect for human right. Consequently, on Thursday the 31st of March 2022, Uromi JDCPI held her 2022 Annual Human Rights Conference.



A cross section of dignitaries at the high table

Photo credit: Uromi JDPCI

The epoch making event which is an annual reflection of the achievement of the Organisation in the fight against human rights violations took place at the Catholic Chancery Complex, Egbele, Uromi with the theme: SEXUAL AND GENDER BASED VIOLENCE (SGBV) AND ITS CASE MANAGEMENT. More specifically, the conference provided a platform to enlighten and

expose participants to the concept of SGBV and ways to effectively respond to and manage SGBV related cases professionally.

The Conference was graced by Stakeholders and Human Right Actors across the State comprising representative from the 30 project communities in Edo Central Senatorial District, Security Agents, Legal and Medical Practitioners, Traditional Rulers, Clergy men, Paralegals and their Supervisors, Men of the Press as well as Management and Staff of Uromi JDPCI.

Remarkable key messages passed at the conference were:

- “Stand against sexual violence, stand against domestic violence and stand against impunity”
- “Violence against Women Isn’t Cultural, it’s Criminal. Equality Cannot Come Eventually, It’s something we must fight for Now”.
- “Your Self-worth, Self-esteem, Health and Life Matters. Break the Silence. Say No to SGBV”
- “Be Supportive, keep yourself, your family and community healthy and protected”
- “Say no to any form of violence including physical, emotional, psychological, sexual or economic violence”
- “Break the silence when you witness violence against a person do not sit back-Act”



An aerial view of the of conference participants



Representative of the Nigerian Bar Association addressing the participants

The Executive Director of Uromi Justice Development, Peace and Caritas Initiative Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo in his key note address enumerated the relevance of the event which



Representative of the Women Medical Association addressing the participants

according to him was an opportunity to itemize and reflect on the achievements and contributions of Uromi JDPCI in the struggle to have an informed and better society devoid of human rights violations. He joyously informed participants of the successes already recorded since the commencement of the scheme which includes; awareness and gradual assimilation of human right principles in the custom and tradition of some community members, as most of the cultural norms which were inimical to natural justice, equity, good conscience and gender equality were undergoing redress in those communities, the willingness to report human right violations by community members as well as interventions on human right violations reported to the commission in Court of Competent Jurisdiction and community human right stakeholders involvements in addressing civil matters through Alternative Dispute Resolution. Conclusively, he appreciated all relevant stakeholders for their effort to achieve and sustain the goal of the organization and enjoined them to continually render their support.

Sequentially, the guest speaker, Miss Priscilla Usiobaifo, the Executive Director of Brave Heart Initiative for Youth and Women, a feminist Non-Governmental Organization, succinctly did justice to the theme; Sexual and Gender Based Violence and its Case Management

At the end of the presentation, reactions and contributions sprang from energized and inspired key stakeholders from across the different sectors who acknowledged the good work of the organization and pledged commitment to support the promotion and protection of human rights with regards to SGBV. Participants were also given the opportunity to ask questions and clarify issues. One of the questions raised was the position of the law with regards to child marriage especially where the parent of the child is in support of the marriage and the said child is against it.

The Guest Speaker responded that the law frowned against child marriage as such perpetrators of such acts were liable to punishment for a term of 5 years or payment of a fine of N50, 000 or



The guest speaker, Priscilla Usiobaifo addressing the conference participants during her presentation

both.



The Executive Director in a group photograph with the participants.

Participants were indeed very delighted to be part of the

conference. They beamed with so much fulfillment to continue in the fight for justice and promotion of human right to sustain their relevance and credence before the village populace.

GOOD GOVERNANCE DESK

COMMUNITY MOBILIZATION AND ENGAGEMENT FOR TRANSPARENCY, ACCOUNTABILITY AND SUSTAINABLE GOVERNANCE IN EDO CENTRAL SENATORIAL DISTRICT

Advocacy Visits to the 25 Project Communities and 5 Local Government Instrumental Stakeholders (Acting Local Government Chairpersons) in Edo Central Senatorial District

In the bid to improve community participation in governance for accountability, transparency and effective service delivery, Uromi JDPCI entered into partnership with the European Union- Agents for Citizen Driven Transformation to implement an intervention known as Community Mobilization and Engagement for Transparency, Accountability and Sustainable



The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI addressing stakeholders in Akho Community
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI.

Governance in Edo Central Senatorial District.

Uromi JDPCI began implementation of this intervention with Advocacy Visits to relevant stakeholders across the 25 project communities and 5 Chairmen of Local Government Areas within the project scope being Edo Central Senatorial District. These activity was led by the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev Fr Dr. Fidelis Arhedo together with the Project Team to raise awareness about the intervention amongst identified stakeholders and to solicit their full participation, involvement and support for the Project so as to achieve its overall objectives which is to have an improved community participation in governance for accountability, transparency and effective service delivery.



The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI addressing stakeholders in Uzea Community
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI.
Igueben Local Government Areas

The communities visited were; Ewu, Usenu, Akho, Opoji, and Agua of Esan Central Local Government Area, Uzea, Eror, Efandion, Amendiokhia and Ivue of Esan North East Local Government Area, Egoro- Amede, EguareEkpoma, Ukpenu, Emaudo and Ukhun of EsanWest Local Government Area and Ewatto, Ewohimi, Emu, Ubijaja and Ekpon in Esan South East

Local Government Area and Okhuesan, Ewatto, Ewohimi, Eguare-Igueben, and Ewossain

The Project Team were given warmth reception by the various communities and Local Government actors who commended the intervention and gave their assurances to engage maximally throughout the implementation process.



The Project Team in a group photograph with stakeholders from Ewu Community
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI.

In the course of the visits, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI explained that the project is designed to address the problem of community neglect by elected representatives and government at all levels, especially the Local Government being the closest to the communities and aimed to promote community participation in governance at the Local Government level and improve their capacity to demand for their right, thereby making elected leaders accountable and transparent to the people. He added that the Project will advocate with and sensitize the communities to raise awareness on how they can maximally participate in grass root governance by engaging their elected representatives at the Local levels so as to get their community inputs into the budget which will result in service delivery in their communities, hence Uromi JDPCI via the project will particularly build the capacity of community representatives (civic groups) in the area of budget tracking and open governance partnership (OGP) so as to identify the particular projects that are meant for their various communities and then follow up to ensure that they are implemented.

The stakeholders in all the 25 communities were very delighted with the intervention and affirmed the fact that they were ignorant and lacked the capacity to either engage or make demands from their elected representatives who most times were inaccessible, unperturbed about their negligence to the communities and dishonest in their dealings with the people. They also proved to be ignorant of government budgets and allocations since previous years and administrations.

They therefore hoped that the intervention would indeed bring about a positive change to their plights and promised to work with Uromi JDPCI to achieve the goal of the intervention.

Similarly, the Local Government Chairmen expressed satisfaction with the stand of the Organization and the lapse the project sought to address.

Advocacy letters were shared with the respective communities and acting Chairmen who acknowledged and gave assurances of their support towards the full implementation of the project within their various jurisdiction.

Project Orientation Meeting for the 25 Civic Groups

Uromi JDPCI proceeded with Local Government Based orientation meetings with the identified and selected community civic group members whose membership constitute of community men, women, young girls, young boys and persons with disabilities across 5 selected communities, in each of the 5 Local Government Areas of Edo Central Senatorial District. This activity was held from the 22nd through 24th of March 2022 at a central venue in each Local Government Area.



Cross session of participants in Igueben Local Government Area

Members of these groups were identified by their various community stakeholders, thus a sum total of 269 persons (156 Males and 113 Females) participated at the orientation meeting.

The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo in his opening remark appreciated members of the various groups for accepting the assignments entrusted on them by their various community stakeholders in becoming members of the newly established Civic Groups. He

intimated them of the relevance of the proposed Civic Groups by stating their roles as community observers and actors whose task was to ensure governmental presence in their various communities by making the elected government officials responsive in their duties and obligations owned to their communities as of right. He stated that this call arouse due to the apparent negligence and failure of the government in meeting the developmental needs of the communities, which problems persisted due to lacunas that exists between members of the community and the people in governance. He elucidated further that their duties as community civic groups entailed bridging the gap between the people in governance and members of the community, through the engagement of their elected representatives to become accountable, transparent as well as ensure sustainable governance in their various communities.



The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI addressing participants in one of the LGAs

Finally, he assured them of plans put in place by the project to build their capacities in areas of budget tracking, open government partnership as well as promotion of community participation in governance and once again appreciated their presence and acceptance to the hallowed but voluntary community task.

Progressively, Dr. Michael Iyoriobhe a member of the Project Management Team took participants through the Project frame work by implicitly emphasizing the goal and objective of the project, the composition of the civic membership, the scope of the intervention which is 25 communities in the 5 Local Government Areas of Edo-Central Senatorial District, indicators in view of the achievements of the goal of the project as well as activities proposed to meet the goal of the project.



Cross session of participants in Esan North East Local Government Area



Cross session of participants in Esan South East Local Government Area

Participants who were deeply exposed to their roles in ensuring that the dividends of democracy is seen and felt in their community, became very enthusiastic and passionate to the cause. Unanimously, they expressed great bitterness over the unpleasant situations faced by the grass root in Edo-State due to concurrent side -linings, marginalization and relegations from supposed community representatives in the governmental helm of affairs. They enumerated areas of negligence by the political actors ranging from agricultural development, health care services, economic empowerments, infrastructures to mention but a few.

Participants were seen to be beaming with more ideas and resolutions to secure governmental presence, accountability, transparency and sustainability at this cradle stage by accepting to become members of political parties in their various communities and wards in order to reduce and possibly stop the imposition of



Cross session of participants in Esan West Local Government Area

electoral candidates on the communities by political god-fathers.

Conclusively, the participants appreciated Uromi JDPCI for the innovative approach to improve the communities and promised to actively participate in the capacity building sessions embedded in the project and apply the lessons learnt which would ultimately lead to the development of their communities.

Quarterly Monitoring Visits to 15 Civic Groups in the 5 Local Government Areas of the Project Scope.

In line with the project's mapped out activity to carry out quarterly monitoring visits to the established civic groups across the 5 Project Local Government Areas in Edo Central Senatorial District, Uromi JDPCI conducted the first phase of monitoring visits to 15 civic groups across the 5 LGAs to provide mentorship for the effective functioning of the groups, render technical support in addressing identified gaps and challenges and also ascertain the extent of the groups engagement with their elected community representatives in harvesting the gains of democracy and achieving the overall objective of the project. This activity took place in the month of March 2022 between the 1st -30th of March 2022



During the monitoring visit to Opoji Civic Group in Esan Central LGA
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

The following community civic groups were visited within the period during their monthly meetings; Egoro-Amede, Eguare- Ekpoma and Ukpenu in Esan West LGA, Amediokhan, Efandion and Eror in Esan North East LGA, Akho, Opoji and Ewu in Esan Central LGA, Ewossa, Uhe and Ekpon in Igubeben LGA and Ubiaja, Ewohimi and Ewatto in Esan South East LGA



The M and E Officer addressing members of Ekpon Civic Group during the monitoring visit
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

Noteworthy resolutions and commitments made by members of the various groups in the course of the visits includes; paying introductory visit to their Head of Local Governments to introduce the civic group members and their roles in the community, call new members to be part of the meeting and have a fixed schedule for their monthly meetings.

Two of the groups raised concerns over the apparent absence of a sitting Local Government Chairman since Local Government election were yet to be conducted, while noting the challenge in engaging their acting chairmen who are civil servants with limited powers to make and enforce certain decisions. Notwithstanding, they were admonished to establish a good working relationship with the acting chairmen and engage them accordingly.

At Egoro-Amede Civic Group in Esan West LGA, it was highlighted by the Civic group members that the Senior School Principal of the community secondary school; Egoro-Amede



During the visit to Egoro-Amede community Civic Group
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

Secondary School charged exorbitant fees from parents for the 2022 Senior Secondary School Certificate Examination. According to them, the approved fee by the State Government was ₦20,000 per child but the Principal collected the sum of ₦50,000, fifty thousand naira from each student. They further revealed that two members of the civic group who are PTA members in the school had earlier made several attempts to dialogue with the principal concerning the issue but she refused them audience.

Sequel to the complaint raised, Uromi JDPCI supported the Civic group to facilitate the report of the fraudulent activity of the School Principal to the Edo State Commissioner for Education, Dr Joan Oviawe who called the principal for questioning but she denied the allegation despite testimonies from some Parents in the community who acknowledged to have paid the said amount (₦50,000) to the Principal. Also, the Principal was reported to have threatened her students on the Assembly ground that she would fish out and deal with the person who reported her to the Commissioner. This threat was immediately escalated by the Civic group members through Uromi JDPCI to the commissioner who after one week, precisely on the 16th of March 2022, gave a directive through the Esan West LGA Chief Inspector of Education (CIE) that the Senior Principal should handover her responsibilities to the Junior School Principal. The said Principal is presently on suspension while investigation is ongoing, though she goes to work but not performing in the capacity of the Senior School Principal of Egoro Amede Community Secondary School.

Also, at Eror Civic Group in Esan North East LGA, it was gathered that members of the group paid a courtesy visit to their one-time representative at the National Assembly, who happened to be a son of the community; to introduce the group and call him to action to re-awaken the commitment made by the Governor of Edo State to construct a road for the community during his governorship campaign. He promised to galvanize actions towards the realization of the commitment made by the Governor and also shared the 2022 state budget with the Civic Group members while assuring them of his support to bring the project to reality since it has already be captured in the 2022 budget.



During the visit to Eror community Civic Group
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

At Opoji Civic Group in Esan Central LGA, members noted that the community primary and secondary school had only a few teachers, with the primary school having just two teachers. They were guided to report the challenge to the Post Primary Education Board which they did and subsequently 5 teachers were posted to the primary school



During the monitoring visit to Opoji
Civic Group in Esan Central LGA
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

They various groups were informed about the training on budget tracking coming up in May 2022 which would build their capacities on how to track government

approved budgets and participate in their LGA budget preparation. They were encouraged not to lose focus but work with determination as a team to achieve good governance in their respective communities

ANTI HUMAN TRAFFICKING DESK

DON'T PAY WITH YOUR LIFE PROJECT

Empowerment of 10 (Ten) Don't Pay With Your Life Caregivers with the 2nd and last Tranche Disbursement of ₦50,000 for Income Generating Activities.

In furtherance of the project's objective to support the livelihood situations of vulnerable households through income generating activities in-order to reduce their susceptibility to human trafficking, Uromi JDPCI on the 8th of February 2022 provided the last tranche disbursement of fifty thousand naira (₦50,000) to the remaining 10 Caregivers (all females) who have invested and demonstrated capacity in managing their respective businesses with the first installment of the ₦100,000 grant received from Uromi JDPCI in the early part of last year (2021)

This activity took place at the Catholic Chancery Complex during the auspicious commemoration of the Feast Day of St. Josephine Bakhita-(Patron Saint of Victims of Slavery and Trafficking) which also doubled as the International Day of Prayer against Human Trafficking.

Prior to the empowerment, the project Team visited the Caregivers' businesses and discussed the overall management of the business, the impact of the business on their livelihood situations, challenges recorded in the business as well as their business expansion plans.

The Caregivers expressed great satisfaction over the support received, promised to remain committed in business and showered accolades and prayers on the Donors and implementers of the project for the support given to them. One of the Caregivers while thanking the Donors and Uromi JDPCI acknowledged that she never imagined that such a huge support could come from people she has never met in her life, adding that the intervention was rare and timely

for her household. They left with smiles on their faces as majority of them received their payment alert while still at the venue of the event.



The Executive Director in a group photograph with the Caregivers

Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

2nd Session of Group Discussion with Don't Pay With Your Life Young Female Returnees held on Friday 25th of March 2022 At Uromi JDPCI Conference Hall, Uromi Edo State.

The 2nd session of group discussion with project beneficiaries -(Young Female Returnees) was conducted by Uromi JDPCI on Friday the 25th of March, 2022 at Uromi JDPCI Conference Hall. The session, which was very interactive and participatory, was facilitated by Erhabor Harriet and the discussion bothered around “SELF IMPROVEMENT” with the objective to stimulate reflective thinking and actions for personal growth and development amongst participants, improve their understanding on the concept of “Self-Improvement” and the need to improve their selves for better productivity in various aspects of life.



One of the Participants contributing to the discussion

It was emphasized that self- improvement demands **conscious effort** by the individual in improving personal skills, competence, talents, knowledge, attitudes and the likes.

Participants were admonished not to get de-motivated in life nor allow the pressures of life break them rather, they should find inspiration from people who have achieved similar things that they want to achieve, draw strength from them while

improving on themselves to create a better future

With optimism, they promised to continually seek ways to improve and advance their lives positively as it is the only way to get better in life.



Participants listening to the Facilitator with rapt attention during the session

Follow-up Visits to the Supported Businesses of Don't Pay With Your Life Young Female Returnees.

Uromi JDPCI within the period visited the businesses of the supported young female returnees under the Don't Pay With Your Life Project to ascertain their business status, evaluate their business performance over the period, determine the impact of the business in their lives, note their challenges and provide technical advice where necessary.

Outcome of the visit revealed that 10 out of the 15 supported beneficiaries which represents 66% were still in business with improvements recorded in business and their livelihood. The Team encouraged them to remain steadfast in their business and see each day as an opportunity for growth.



While recounting the impact of the empowerment in their lives, one of the Beneficiaries relayed that she was no longer stressed nor disturbed especially in the aspect of feeding, she is more focused,

hopeful for a great future and hopes that her business grows into a very big supermarket someday

Another Beneficiary particularly stated that her income has increased since she started her clothing business compared to when she was just buying and selling fruits in the market. She also mentioned that the business management training provided really helped her to manage her business well with successes recorded in the areas of sales, cash flow and gains.



Yet another related to the Team that the economic assistance of the project has changed her financial status from depending on her mother for livelihood to being self-dependent. In her words “waking up in the morning and going to my shop to work, gives me a sense of happiness and fulfilment”. She also explained that her encounter with the Project revolutionized her thinking patterns as prior to this time she never thought one could start something small and grow it big; reiterating that seeing her

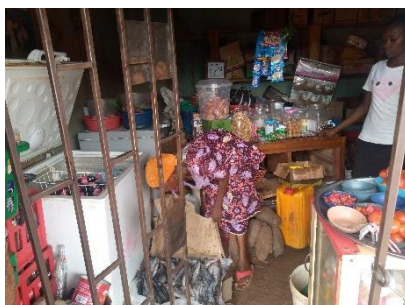
business grow over the months makes her very optimistic about the future. She recounted the discouragements she had from friends when she started her business but her Mother’s advice and the counsel and mentorship she continually got from Uromi JDPCI kept her focused all the while. Her plans are to expand her business, stock variety of human hair in her shop and also get married and raise a family.

They thanked the Team and the Donors for the great love, encouragement and support given them.

Fifth Phase of Monitoring Visits to Supported Caregivers in Edo Central Senatorial District Held From the 7th of January to 24th of February 2022

The Project Team equally paid monitoring visit to the 50 supported caregivers across the 5 LGAs. Findings from the monitoring visits revealed that 40 of the caregivers representing 80% were still active in business while 10 have fallen out of business due to sickness, mismanagement of funds, death of the caregiver, and health challenges of their family members.

Those still in business have had significant improvement in their livelihood situations especially in the area of feeding and in meeting the daily and educational needs of their children.



It was also observed that some of them had issues stabilizing their businesses due to the inflation rate of the economy, thus posing a great threat to the survival of the



businesses. However, a number of them have demonstrated capacity to manage their businesses even in the face of the declined economic conditions; their businesses have improved overtime with sustainability in view.

Of the 18 students that the project enrolled for the 2021 Senior Secondary School Certificate Examination, 16 of them passed all their papers in the examination but 2 had their results seized. However one of them has been re enrolled to take the exams by her caregiver while the second person could not due to financial constraint. Also 8 out of the 16 would be taking the Joint Admission and Matriculation Board (JAMB) examination by May 2022 to pursue a degree in the university while another would be writing the entrance examination to Igueben College of Education to pursue a degree in education. Only four (4) of the Beneficiaries have taken up vocational skills as an alternative to tertiary education while the others who have intensions of following similar line have not been able to register for their vocational training due to financial constraint.

Among, the first set of children that graduated from secondary school in 2020, two of them have almost completed their vocational training but do not have the resources in view to start up after the training;



while another is in her second year at Igueben College of Education.

For those still in secondary school, 17 of them have enrolled for the 2022 senior secondary school certificate examination while 8 others have been promoted to new classes. Unfortunately 2 of the Children dropped out of school as one got pregnant and could not finish her secondary education and another stopped school after relocating to Benin City to live with her sister.

STRENGTHENING COMMUNITY PARTICIPATION TO PREVENT HUMAN TRAFFICKING IN EDO CENTRAL SENATORIAL DISTRICT (SCOPPH-T PROJECT)

Empowerment of 31 Most Vulnerable Caregivers with a Grant of 100,000 for Income Generating Activities and Provision of Educational Support to 75 in -School Adolescent Children.

In line with the mapped out project activities, Uromi JDPCI on Tuesday the 8th of February, 2021 in an event held at the Catholic Chancery Complex successfully empowered a total of 31 most vulnerable caregivers across Esan Central and Igueben Local Government Areas (LGAs) respectively with the sum of 100,000 naira being grant for income generating activities with the goal to improve their socio economic

situations and reduce the vulnerability of their households to human trafficking. 17 of the caregivers were from Esan Central while 14 were from Igueben.



The Executive Director in a group photograph with the empowered caregivers holding out their dumcheque of 100,000
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

Prior to the empowerment, the beneficiaries (caregivers) were equipped with knowledge on business management and entrepreneurial skills for effective delivery in their chosen business endeavors.

The event also featured the empowerment of the 75 most vulnerable children (32 males, 43 females) who were selected through a structured assessment across 26 public schools in Edo Central Senatorial District. The Children were provided with a complete set of text books for secondary schools, branded exercise books, a school bag and sandals including payment of all mandatory school levies for the session. 41 of the children were from Junior Secondary School (JSS1-JSS3) while 34 were from Senior Secondary school (SS1-SS3).



The Executive Director in a group photograph with beneficiaries of SCOPPH-T
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

These gestures strives at ensuring school retention and livelihood support for income generating activities for vulnerable households

Sensitization to Schools

As part of efforts to ensure that Community members are aware of the high risks of trafficking associated with irregular migration and are in capacity to inform others, Uromi JDPCI engaged intensive sensitization and awareness creation on the dangers inherent in human trafficking to students across 9 schools namely; Okhuesan Secondary school, Ewatto Grammar school, Agadaga-Ewohimi Secondary School, Ujeolen Grammar School, Uhiele Grammar school, Equare Secondary School, Agba Grammar School, Igueben College, Igueben grammar school, Ekekeh-Idumuogo Secondary school and Ebelle Grammar school.



The SCOPPH-T Project Team enlightened the students on the meaning of human trafficking which is the illegal and irregular migration of victims internally and externally for exploitation purposes. The causes behind such heinous acts were explained to include poverty, greed and ignorance. Furthermore, the students were taught that human trafficking could lead to death of the victims because of the sufferings, sexual harassment and other vices they often encounter. Then after, the intricacies of human trafficking were shown to the pupils via a documentary of true life coverage of experiences of human trafficking.



At Okhuesan Secondary School, one of the student asked if all who travel to Libya have to pass through such dangerous route. In response they were told that Libya is an irregular and illegal route to Europe with so many dangers on the way. Another student also asked if it was right for



them to obey their parents when asked to go leave with a relative. In response they were told to take home the lessons they learnt from the documentary that was shown to them on Child abuse and enlighten their parents so that they do not fall victim to possible abuse.

Sensitization to Markets

Uromi JDPCI visited nine markets for campaign against Human Trafficking and irregular migration. The purpose of which was to create awareness on the ills of human trafficking and irregular migration. An estimated total of 10,752 persons made up of 924 males and 10,224 females were reached. The markets visited were Ewu and Irrua market in Esan Central LGA, Ebelle market in Igueben LGA, Ubiaja and Ahia market in Esan South East LGA, Ekpoma new market and Ekpoma market square in Esan West LGA, Ebhoyi market and Uromi market in Esan North East LGA. The team spoke on the dangers of human trafficking and the risk it poses to the lives of young persons, their families and the community in general.



The market women and men expressed appreciation to the team for the information shared with them and requested for routine visit to the market by the team to constantly refresh the minds of the people as well as enable the information to be well disseminated in the market and



Urohi Community Sensitization

community at large. Some of the women also expressed shock over the ordeals related by victims in the video documentaries shown.

Sensitization to Communities

Uromi JDPCI equally engaged intensive sensitization and awareness creation in communities and took the message of the dangers inherent in human trafficking to the people in the communities. The purpose was to enlighten community members about the menace of human trafficking and Irregular Migration so as to reduce their susceptibility of falling prey

to human traffickers as well as discouraging them from supporting and facilitating irregular travels. In the course of the sensitizations in the various communities, The Project Team raised the need for Participants to stop human trafficking and irregular migration. They were made to understand the exploitative nature of human trafficking, the types of human trafficking, its effects and consequences on the individual, their families and the community at large and their roles in preventing the menace as well as a call to action to end human trafficking



Akho Community Sensitization



Ivue community sensitization



Equare-Ebelle Community Sensitization

in their communities, shaming and bringing Traffickers to book. A total of 5 communities were sensitized with 149 persons reached (63 males and 86 females). The communities visited were Agua, Equare-Ebelle, Akho, Urohi and Ivue communities respectively. The various communities were pleased with the sensitization and gave assurances to take the messages received to other members of the community.

Anti-Human Trafficking Clubs Meetings in Ten (10) Secondary Schools Across the Five (5) Local Government Areas

The project team of Uromi JDPCI conducted learning sessions with members of the anti-human trafficking clubs across 10 Government Secondary Schools namely: Igueben College and Igueben Grammar School in Igueben Local Government Area, Arue Secondary School and Agba Grammar School in Esan North-East Local Government Area, Eguare Secondary School and Emaudo Secondary School in Esan West Local Government Area, Obiaza mixed secondary school Ubiaja and St Johnbosco secondary school in Esan South East LGA, Irrua girls secondary school and Annunciation Catholic College in Esan Central LGAs respectively.



During the session at Igueben College

The Anti-Human Trafficking club is to serve as a forum for peer education and information sharing amongst school children on issues of human trafficking and irregular migration in-order to rightly mold the perception of Adolescents and youths in the various communities/LGAs on issues of human trafficking and irregular migration.



Cross session of students during the session at Agba Grammar School

The students were taught the criminality of the act of trafficking persons and the right of children to be free from every form of human trafficking and exploitation. Using the child's right law in force in Edo State, the student were taken through section 33 which states that any form of exploitation of a child was an offence and punishable under the law with a fine of 50000 or a term of five years or both.

At the end of the club meetings, the students' became more knowledgeable about the menace of human trafficking and irregular migration. This was ascertained through their responses to the knowledge assessment questions presented to them during the club's productive knowledge sharing sessions.

Community Dialogue in 5 Communities

The project also engaged in community dialogue with stakeholders in 5 communities so as to ensure that Local authorities, Communities and child protection networks have improved understanding of causes and issues associated with human trafficking/irregular migration and are better equipped to contribute to prevention strategies. The communities visited for



the dialogue session were; Amedokhian, Ubiaja, Ehuare-Ekpoma, Ewossa and Ewu Communities.

Participants understanding of the concept of human trafficking and what it entailed were broadened through the dialogue and they understood the fact that anyone could be a victim of human trafficking and as such communities needed to keep watch of the activities of traffickers and help shame and bring identified perpetrators to book by reporting them to concerned authorities.

Victim Support Group Meetings in the 5 LGAs of the Program Intervention

As part of effort to promote re-integration for victims of human trafficking in Edo Central Senatorial District, Uromi JDPCI engaged in meetings with the 5 victim support groups in the five Local Government



Esan West Support Group Meeting

Areas (LGAs) in the senatorial district. In the course of the meeting, the Project was re-introduced to them as Strengthening

Community Participation to Prevent Human Trafficking (SCOPPH-T). They were told

that the purpose of the meeting was to promote re-integration and develop synergy among them for effective Mental Health and Psychosocial Support. The platform would also assist them to support

themselves and collectively push for the achievement of certain benefits that they would not get as individuals. They were urged to be ambassadors in the campaign against human trafficking and irregular migration in their various communities and the society at large, using their life experiences. They were also taught on resilience and self-improvement to help build their capacity to counsel and provide psychological first aid to members and potential victims. The project team further informed them that their groups, if effectively positioned would be able to recommend victims who have not been supported by any other project or body for livelihood support and economic reintegration.

The Members of the various groups expressed interest to work with the project team and also shared their challenges since their return to Nigeria. Some of them requested to know when the assistance offered by the project would be given to them. During



Esan North East Support Group meeting

discussion it was observed that many of them

would require psychosocial support especially in the area of counseling to fully understand and appreciate their current situation as well as help

them to develop the skill of harnessing their individual resources to make a meaning out of their lives by starting with the little that they have and then grow it into something big. Many of them have very high expectation and think that they cannot start any meaningful enterprise unless they have Millions. The project team reminded them of the need to form themselves into a group so as to continually share ideas for growth and development.



Igueben Support Group Meeting



Esan Central Support Meeting

SUSTAINABLE MEASURES AGAINST TRAFFICKING IN PERSONS (SMAT-P) PROJECT

Empowerment of 33 Skilled Vulnerable Youths with Business Start -up Equipment/Materials held on the 8th of February 2022 at the Catholic Chancery Complex Egbele, Uromi

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives recorded another milestone with the empowerment of 33 skilled beneficiaries (27 females and 6 males) across 7 skills set with business start-up equipment/materials through her SMAT-P Project- Sustainable Measures Against Trafficking In-Persons; coordinated by Caritas Nigeria via the financial support of the Italian Bishops Conference.

This activity took place on the 8th of February 2022 at the Catholic Chancery Complex during the auspicious commemoration of the Feast Day of St. Josephine Bakhita which also doubled as the International Day of Prayer against Human Trafficking.

The beneficiaries were selected through a structured assessment and validation exercise after which they underwent a one day training on business management and entrepreneurship to build their capacity to effectively manage their businesses and become great entrepreneurs.



Cross session of the Beneficiaries standing close to their equipment
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

This support contributes to the realization of the overarching objectives of the project in addressing the menace of human trafficking and irregular migration through awareness creation and empowerment.



A barbing beneficiary being presented his start-up equipment

The Beneficiaries expressed great satisfaction over the support received and promised to make good use of their start up equipment and would not disappoint the Donors. They

appreciated Caritas Nigeria and Uromi JDPCI for the support given to them.



A session of the beneficiaries during the opening prayer
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI



During the presentation of start-up equipment to beneficiaries by the Executive Director and the NAPTIP Zonal Commander
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI



One of the Benefiting Youths receiving her tailoring equipment
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

Barr Mrs Chidiebere Oruruo Ifufu, the NAPTIP Zonal Commander for Edo together with the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI made the presentation of start-up materials to the beneficiaries.

COMMEMORATION OF THE FEAST DAY OF ST. JOSEPHINE BAKHITA

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives (Uromi JDPCI) remarkably commemorated the feast day of St. Josephine Bakhita: Patron Saint of trafficked victims and slavery on the 8th day of February, 2022 at the Catholic Chancery Complex, Egbele, Uromi by 11:00am. It also doubled as the 'International Day of Prayers and Awareness against Human Trafficking and was used to empower a total of 149 persons across three interventions implemented by Uromi JDPCI namely: (Strengthening Community Participation to prevent Human Trafficking in Edo Central Senatorial District, Don't Pay with Your Life Program and the Sustainable Measures Against Trafficking in Persons Project. .

The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev Fr Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, in his Welcome Address stated the significance of the day, which is basically a call to all and sundry to work together to reduce the most cause of human trafficking in Edo state and push further to ameliorate the harsh economic condition in their own little way. Fr Arhedo

said this event is annually celebrated to mark the feast of St Josephine Bakhita, who in the history of the Catholic Church is regarded as the Patron Saint of Victims of Slavery and Human Trafficking.



**The Executive Director delivering his
Keynote address**
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

Furthermore, Very Rev Fr Dr. Fidelis Arhedo narrated a brief history of St Josephine Bakhita who hailed from Sudan in Africa. She was kidnapped sold and resold into slavery by her adopters and tortured by her slave masters until she met the Cannasian sisters who later helped her to get freedom. With this event in her life and her deep conviction as a Christian, she became interested in the apostolate of the nuns who rescued her in their caring for the poor children (orphans inclusive). She became a nun and today, the church celebrates her feast although is an optional memorial. Fr. Arhedo explained that the memorial is an important event for the Organisation in her fight to eradicate human trafficking, which is modern day slavery, because, it is within the mandate of Uromi JDPCI to eradicate human trafficking and help to sensitize the people that human trafficking is evil as well as educate the people that irregular migration often fuels human trafficking.

The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev Fr Dr Fidelis Arhedo in his final note stated that Uromi JDPCI, in partnership with other organizations have created alternatives to human trafficking in her empowerment scheme, vocational training, school retention and livelihood support for income generating activities for the vulnerable households inorder to eradicate the root causes of human trafficking and irregular migration.

In conclusion, he appreciated Caritas Nigeria, ECPAT France and Luxembourg as well as Expertise France for their supports, which made the celebration possible. Lastly, he exhorted the beneficiaries

to make the most of the awards given to them, as Uromi JDPCI would regularly monitor their performances.

The Zonal Commander of the National Agency for the Prohibition of Trafficking in Persons (NAPTIP) Benin Zonal Command, Barr Mrs. Chidiebere R. Oruruo-Ifudu, also used the occasion to



The Executive Director and NAPTIP Zonal Commander presenting startup kits to a SMAT-P beneficiary

Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

sensitize the participants on the dangers inherent in human trafficking. In her words, ‘Human Trafficking is modern day Slavery’. She recounted plethora of sad cases of human trafficking she had handled over the years and encouraged everyone to speak out against any form of human

trafficking by calling the NAPTIP hot line, which is 09061645732 to



The Acting Chairman of Esan North East LGA presenting a scholarship award to a SCOPPH-T beneficiary

Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI

report cases of trafficking in persons. On a final note, she appreciated the laudable efforts and interventions of Uromi JDPCI and advised the beneficiaries to use their opportunities wisely.

The beneficiaries who were beaming with joy and happiness expressed great appreciation to Uromi JDPCI and promised to be assiduous with the support given to them.

ORPHANS AND VULNERABLE CHILD DESK:

INTEGRATED CHILD HEALTH AND SOCIAL SERVICE AWARD (ICHSSA 2) PROJECT

Caregivers Forum at Esan South East, Esan West and Esan Central LGAs

The Caregivers forum at the local government level (LGA) is a platform to increase caregiver’s knowledge and skills to be able to provide nutritional, social, emotional and financial needs of a child and the immediate household.

In this quarter (January-March, 2022), the first forum meetings with Caregivers were held in three LGAs; Esan South East, Esan West and Esan Central on the 15th 16th and 17th of March, 2022 respectively with discussions centered on **Agricultural Counseling** (setting up home gardens) and **Nutrition** focusing on food demonstration for age-appropriate healthy meals to meet nutritional needs of Children living with HIV as well as Orphans and Vulnerable Children.

During the Caregivers forum at the aforementioned LGAs emphasis were laid on the importance of promoting home gardening to improve and provide access to locally available food that are nutritionally adequate, safe and cost effective.

In the course of the sessions, the caregivers listed food sources that could be cultivated or reared around homes/ gardens, with most caregivers listing vegetables and fruits.

A caregiver from Esan South East, revealed that aside the cultivation of vegetable such as okro, tomatoes, pepper, Ugwu and bitter leaf in her garden, she also owns a poultry farm behind her

house which serves the dual purpose of meat production for family consumption and household income generation. This poultry farm has sustained her household in providing their basic needs. The Caregivers were enlightened on the different types of home gardening they can explore such as container gardening, which entails growing plants in containers and bags. They were thus



Cross Section of caregivers giving feedback on the food demonstration process and taste

encouraged to maximize their immediate environment for agricultural purposes, to meet the nutritional needs of children.

The Project Team also facilitated **food demonstration sessions** across the meeting locations. The Community case managers/caregivers supported the process by sourcing for readily available food items in the community for the demonstration.

Food demonstration was explained as a process of conveying nutritional information to a target group in this case; caregivers through cooking and sharing nutritional tips appropriate for children of different age groups. It includes discussing different available foods and how they can be used, as well as preparing the food together with the caregivers and tasting the prepared meal.

The processes involved in the preparation of two nutritious meals, Tom brown and Vegetable Soup and fufu commonly called Ema were explained to the caregivers; however the Team only demonstrated the preparation of Vegetable Soup and fufu

The caregivers actively participated in the cooking and cleaning of the kitchen utensils.



Demonstration of hygiene practices before handling food at Esan West Caregivers Forum

At the end of the sessions, all caregivers promised to meet the nutritional needs of their children and practice home gardening for easy access to basic food needs.

The Formation of Operation Triple Zero (OTZ) Club for Adolescents at Uromi Central Hospital Uromi (UCH) and Irrua Specialist Teaching Hospital, (ISTH)

The need for an interactive platform for HIV positive adolescents between the age of 10 to 17 years where members can interact as active stakeholders regarding personal health, HIV literacy, Sexual and reproductive health education, prompted Uromi DPCI's formation of two OTZ clubs for adolescents at Uromi Central Hospital and Irrua Specialist and Teaching Hospital on January 22 and March 25, 2022 respectively. The OTZ Cub formation meetings began with the registration of participants at 11:00 am, and opening prayers. Then, the JDPCI Program Manager for the ICHSSA 2 Project facilitated the session regarding the introduction of participants and caregivers as well as the setting of ground rules and meeting expectations.

The Program Manager offered the welcome address stating the rationale for the meeting while referring to the OTZ club as a platform to engage HIV-positive adolescents between 10 to 17 years enrolled in the ICHSSA 2 Project. She revealed that the club is an interactive platform where members can interact as active stakeholders regarding personal health, prompting knowledge on comprehensive HIV literacy and experience sharing. Furthermore, she gave the meaning of the term OTZ as Operation Triple Zero while relating it to achieving ‘three Zeroes’: Zero missed appointments, zero missed medications/drugs, and zero Viral Load (VL).

The club members were charged to take ownership of personal health, participate in decision-making processes and promote positive behaviors. They were equally enlightened about lifetime adherence to treatment and its importance in viral suppression while emphasizing that a virally suppressed ALHIV ie Adolescent Living with HIV is less likely to fall sick, thereby boosting productivity and reducing production losses- reducing both missed school hours or work hours and costs associated with hospitalization.

During the question-and-answer session, an OTZ member inquired about the importance of taking drugs daily? The program officer responded by listing the importance of not missing ART dose, known as adherence to antiretroviral treatment, revealing that this will eventually lead to viral suppression.

Financial Literacy Training for Caregivers in Uromi Cluster

The Association for Reproductive and Family Health – Integrated Child Health and Social Service Award (ARFH-ICHSSA 2) in collaboration with Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas initiatives (Uromi JDPCI) organized a two days financial literacy training for her caregivers. The training held at Uromi JDPCI office complex (Chancery Hall) on the 21st and 22 of March 2022 with a total of 90 caregivers (17males and 73 females) in attendance. The training was aimed at equipping caregivers with basic skills on how to manage their businesses and finances (record keeping) so as to be able to cater for the basic needs of their children in the midst of economic hardship. It was also a necessary criterion for eligibility for the cash transfer which requires them to be linked to village savings and loan association (VSLA).

In the address by the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo welcomed and appreciated the ARFH team for their collaboration. He also welcomed and praised the courage of the caregivers that were present. He then spoke on the essence of training and the need to collaborate to see how we can make life better for all particularly the vulnerable in our society. He therefore enjoined them to listen attentively to the presentations as well as participate actively in the course of the training.

Participants were taught the concept of financial education, the need to establish goals, understanding income and expenses and budget as well as identifying business opportunities.

Additionally, the training was used to sensitize caregivers on gender norms. The discussions were centered on Gender and sex, Gender norms, Gender based violence, Gender and child protection, Male involvement, Women empowerment, Sexual and reproductive health education for adolescent.

Support Group Meetings at Esan Central, Esan North East, Esan West and Esan South East LGAs

As part of the implementation of the ICHSSA 2 Project in Edo State, Uromi JDPCI program team supported and participated in support group meetings in four LGAs; Esan Central (Fountain of Hope Support Group), Esan North East (God is Able Support Group), Esan West (Eseose Support Group) and Esan South East (Divine Grace Support Group). The meetings aimed to strengthen the groups to provide psychosocial support, nutrition care and support, adherence education and income generating activities for ICHSSA 2 Caregivers in various project LGAs.

During the course of the meetings, the Program Manager highlighted the ICHSSA 2 Project Goal and Objectives which entails mitigating the impact of HIV/AIDS on orphans and vulnerable children (OVC) and their families through comprehensive service provision. Moreover, she spelt out the role of the support group in service delivery as, to ensure the enrollment of Children living with HIV and HIV exposed infants into the project. This will ensure the targeted population benefits from the available services.

While encouraging them on the benefits of adherence to medication, they were admonished on the need to show commitment to their medication and continue adherence even after attaining viral suppression.

Uromi JDPCI Monthly Review Meetings with the Community and Facility Case Managers held on January 28th, February 25th and March 30th 2022 respectively.

Within the Period, (January-March 2022), the Uromi JDPCI ICHSSA 2 Project Team had 3 monthly review meetings with the community and facility case managers on January 28th, February 25th and 30th of March, 2022 respectively. The meetings reviewed the JDPCI ARFH-ICHSSA 2 project activities for the period and was geared towards helping the team to deliberate on targeted activities, monthly achievement and seek ways to bridge gaps in program implementation. The review meetings was also used as a platform to step down training on Gender Norms. The Composition of Participants in the respective meetings included the 7 project staff, 1 support staff, 4 Facility Case Managers (FCMs), 12 community Case Managers (CCMs), and the program Monitor



Cross session of participants during the January 2022 review meeting



Cross session of participants during the February 2022 review meeting

The meetings commenced with opening formalities- opening prayers, registration of participants, self- introduction and welcome address. Highlights of activities during the meetings were: update on enrollment and monthly achievements which were presented by the Project Team, the CCMs and the FCMs, review



Cross session of participants during the March 2022 review meeting

of service provisions, review and update of enrollment forms, development of monthly work plan by the CCMs, and step down training on gender norms.

The step down training on gender norms explored the concept of gender and sex as well as the essentials of Gender Based Violence and how it relates to HIV. Basically, the training had components of education, instruction and interaction.

Challenges and concerns were also raised during the course of the meetings and they were adequately addressed by the project Team.

MICRO CREDIT DESK

Uromi JDPCI Micro Credit Scheme was established to provide soft loans to groups that are into enterprise development and active rural farmers who wish to move from subsistence farming to small scale commercial farming. Till date, the Micro Credit scheme is covering the five (5) Local Government Areas in Uromi Diocese and has empowered a total 1,043 persons across 97 groups under its various platforms consisting of Group Micro Credit, Agric Micro Credit, PROMIC 1, 2 and Agric PROMIC through provision of soft loans for economic activities which has in turn improved their livelihood.

INSTITUTIONAL STRENGTHENING AND STAFF CAPACITY BUILDING

Uromi JDPCI 2022 Annual Retreat

Uromi JDPCI commenced her fiscal year 2022 with a two days annual retreat for her Staff to get them prepared for the year and rekindle their zeal and commitment to work as well as to seek God's face in their personal and work life.

The retreat which is a yearly event for the Organisation was held at Brother Roman Centre, Ekpoma between the 6th and 7th of February 2022 with all members of Staff in attendance. (8 males and 7 females)

Rev. Fr. Dr. Francis Obaweiki directed the retreat and took participants on the theme: "Work as participation in the creativity of God". Thus, the psychology of Work was being viewed from a theo-centric perspective with the following topics extensively discussed; God as the author of work, individual perception of work, the changing nature of work, the types of employees and productivity, the concept of motivation, motivation perspectives, appraisal performance, leadership styles and organizational psychology.

The sessions were very involving with series of group discussions, brain warming exercises and self-assessments. Other activities conducted in the course of the retreat included the celebration of Holy mass, prayer of the Rosary and personal prayers and meditation.

The retreat was an eye opener for Staff as was stated by many with relevant knowledge gained. A staff noted that it was the best retreat she has attended since joining the Organisation and hoped to imbibe all lessons learnt.

Two Days Training on International Protection for Mixed Movement Intervention Partners in Edo State

Uromi JDPCI participated in a two day training on International Protection for Mixed Movement Intervention Partners in Edo State organized by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees. The training



Participants paying rapt attention during one of the presentations

which took place between the 15th and



Cross session of participants during the training

16th of March 2022 was held at Vichi Gate Hotel, Benin City with a total of 56 Participants in attendance drawn from different government, religious and civil society organizations among which were NAPTIP, Caritas Nigeria, Idia Renaissance, Name foundation, COSUDOW, JDPC Benin, Uromi JDPCI, JDPC Benin Province, Pathfinders for Justice, ETAHT, Salvation Army, Genius Hub and GERA. The training had the specific objective to equip Partners with the necessary knowledge and tools for identification, protection and assistance of victims of human trafficking especially those who may need International Protection. Thus presentations were given around human trafficking background and Statistics including national and international protection framework for combating human trafficking, international refugee protection, Asylum Policy and Practice in Nigeria, Mixed Movement, Protection from Sexual Exploitation and Abuse, Potential solutions for foreign victims of trafficking under national migration law, review of draft SOP on referral guidelines for NAPTIP and NCFRMI and Communication for development

The Presentations were facilitated by Staff of UNHCR, representative of the National Commission for Refugees, representative of NAPTIP National Command Abuja, the NAPTIP Zonal Commander for Edo Command and representative of the Nigeria Immigration Service, Edo State.

Step Down Training for Staff on Human Resource Strategy

In the bid to enhance staff performance, Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas initiatives (Uromi JDPCI) organized a one day step down training for her staff on Human Resource Strategy. The training objective was to support staff to better understand, design, and apply techniques to further develop Human Resource capabilities and systems and also help them ensure that activities and programmes are more standardized from a Human Resources perspective. Consequently, improving their ability to achieve set objectives and achieve peak performance in their respective job responsibilities.

This training which was facilitated by Very Rev. Fr. Dr Fidelis Arhedo, the Executive Director Uromi JDPCI was held on the 11th of March, 2022 at Uromi JDPCI office conference hall and 19 staff (8 females, 11males) were in attendance. Key areas in Human Resource; which are Human Resource Strategy and goals of an effective human resource strategy, how to Measure Staff Effectiveness, Monitor and Review of staff performance were extensively treated.

5-days Training on Advocacy and Budget Planning organised by Palladium SCALE for clusters anchors from the 14th- 18th of February 2022 at Ikeja Lagos State.

As part of capacity building interventions, Uromi JDPCI Participated in the SCALE ADVOCACY Training organized by SCALE with resource partners from ACIOE, PLAC, TRACKA, and BudgIT at Citiheight Hotel Ikeja Lagos State.

The training was attended by 40 participants from 8 different clusters; which are AHDC, SDN, EMINET, ANEEJ, UROMI JDPCI, LCD, YAF and LAPDO respectively.

Thus, within the duration of the training, attempts were made to examine the meaning, purpose, basic steps and pitfalls of Advocacy, Concept of Advocacy, Advocacy process, Advocacy Issue Identification, Setting Advocacy goal and Objectives, Advocacy Stakeholders Analysis and Mapping, and the likes of other interesting Advocacy related topics. The sessions were participatory and involved brain warming exercises, group works and presentations.



Group Exercise Presentation by the
DOP, Uromi JDPCI
Photo Credit: Uromi JDPCI